

As Manipur conflict persists, one community faces sporting exclusion

For the **second straight year** since the start of ethnic conflict in the state, not a single member of the Kuki-Zo community has been included in the Manipur team for the National Games.

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Despite the civil unrest that has ravaged Manipur for the better part of the last two years, the state has maintained its reputation as one of India's most prodigious sources of sporting talent. At the close of the National Games, the state had won 52 medals, placing it in the top 10 of the medal tally.

However, while the conflict has affected all sections of the population, one side has faced a disproportionate impact. Not a single player from the Kuki-Zo tribe, which comprises some 16 per cent of the state's population, was part of the 416-member Manipur team at the 2025 National Games in Uttarakhand — although other minority groups, including Nagas and Manipuri Muslims, were. There was no Kuki-Zo representation in the Manipur team at the previous edition in Goa either.

This has not always been the case. Players from the Kuki-Zo community have represented Manipur at previous editions of the National Games, particularly in football. Five members of the state football team at the 2022 National Games were from the community. Since the outbreak of violence, however, that has not happened.

According to officials from the Manipur Olympic Association, the difficulty of organising competitions is largely to blame. "We got confirmation that the National Games were going to be held only a couple of months before the Games opened. With the situation as it is in Manipur, it was a huge task even to organise trials and assemble a team to compete at the Games. We did the best with what was possible," says N. Ibungochoubi, the joint secretary of the Manipur Olympic Association.

While it is true that the Games were held on short notice, it is also true that every trial and camp was held in the region of the state capital, Imphal. All state sport federation offices are also in the city. As things stand, Imphal remains a no-go zone for some ethnicities.

"Unfortunately for us, all the state sports federations,



facilities, and resources are in Imphal. Our players can't go there for competition, trials, training, or camps. So, of course, they will not be part of any state team. It's a matter of our lives or the sport. Life is more important," says David Suantak, founder of Play4Change Football Club in Saikhul, which reached the semifinals of the Indian U-18 club football championships last year. Although the club is based in Manipur, they compete in the Meghalayan league since it's impossible for their players to play in Imphal.